

COMPLETE CHESS LEARNING LIBRARY

The Semi-Slav Defense for White

Meran, Anti-Meran, Moscow, Anti-Moscow, and the critical central breaks

TRAINING WORKBOOK

20 focused chapters - model positions - decision rules - retrieval practice

Designed to change what you notice, calculate, remember, and do at the board.

Workbook Method

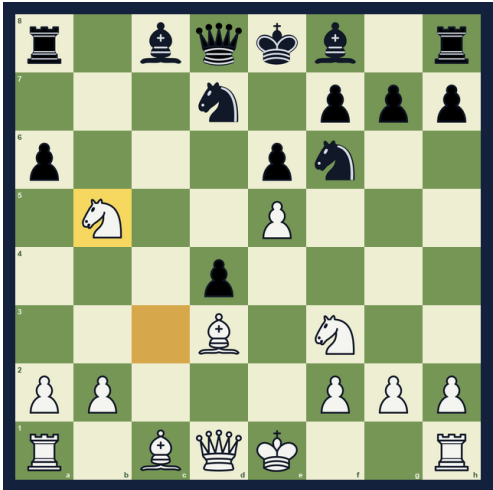
Attempt each page before reopening the matching course-book chapter. Speak answers aloud or write them. The self-score rewards a clear decision rule and the opponent's best reply, not a lucky move guess.

REVIEW THRESHOLD

8-10: review in one week. 5-7: review tomorrow. 0-4: reread the course chapter now, then retry from a blank board.

Use the workbook again after a game reaches a related structure. Real-game retrieval is the final test.

01. Meran Main Line



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

POSITION PROMPT

The Meran releases Black's light bishop with b5 and Bb7, while White builds e4-e5 and accepts a forcing central battle.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Bd3 dxc4 7. Bxc4 b5 8. Bd3 a6 9. e4 c5 10. e5 cxd4 11. Nxb5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

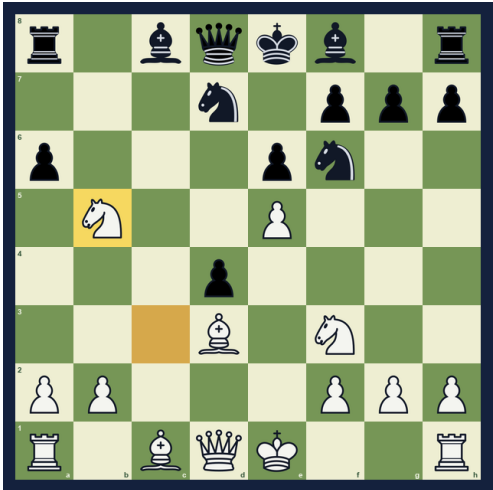
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

02. Meran Main Line



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

POSITION PROMPT

The Meran releases Black's light bishop with b5 and Bb7, while White builds e4-e5 and accepts a forcing central battle.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Bd3 dxc4 7. Bxc4 b5 8. Bd3 a6 9. e4 c5 10. e5 cxd4 11. Nxb5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

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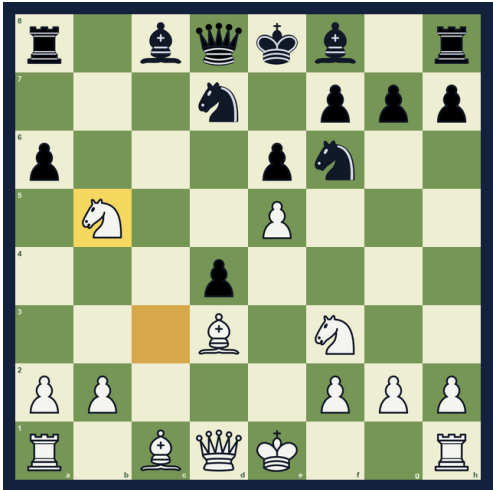
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03. Meran Main Line



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

POSITION PROMPT

The Meran releases Black's light bishop with b5 and Bb7, while White builds e4-e5 and accepts a forcing central battle.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Bd3 dxc4 7. Bxc4 b5 8. Bd3 a6 9. e4 c5 10. e5 cxd4 11. Nxb5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

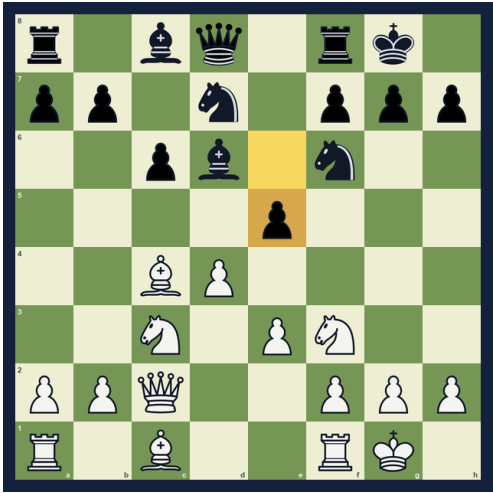
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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

04. Anti-Meran with Qc2



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

POSITION PROMPT

Qc2 supports e4, protects h7 pressure, and delays the bishop commitment so White can meet Meran ideas with more flexibility.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Qc2 Bd6 7. Bd3 O-O 8. O-O dxc4 9. Bxc4 e5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

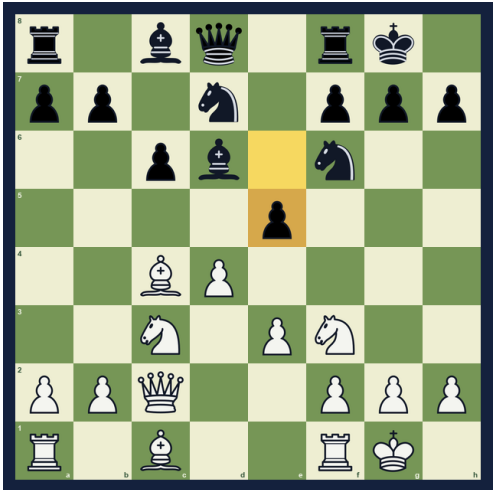
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05. Anti-Meran with Qc2



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

POSITION PROMPT

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REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Qc2 Bd6 7. Bd3 O-O 8. O-O dxc4 9. Bxc4 e5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

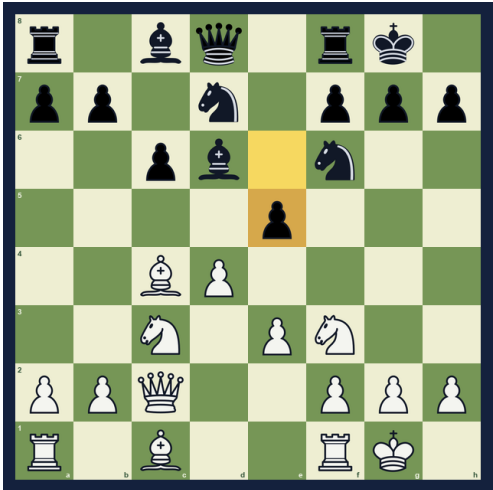
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SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

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REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Qc2 Bd6 7. Bd3 O-O 8. O-O dxc4 9. Bxc4 e5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

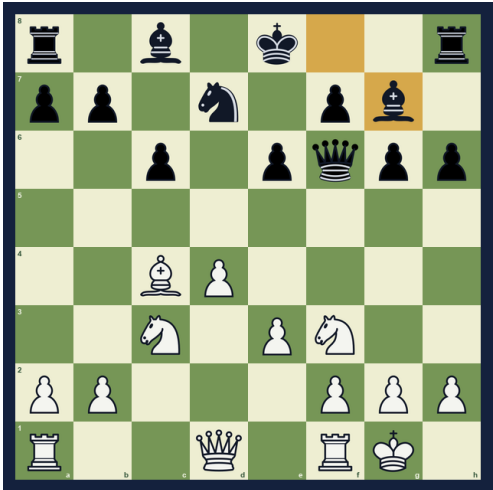
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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

07. Moscow Variation



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

POSITION PROMPT

White exchanges on f6, giving Black the bishop pair but avoiding the sharpest Anti-Moscow and Botvinnik complications.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. Bg5 h6 6. Bxf6 Qxf6 7. e3 Nd7 8. Bd3 dxc4 9. Bxc4 g6 10. O-O Bg7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

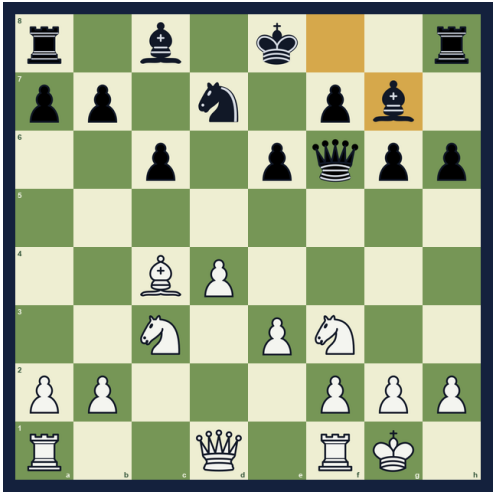
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

08. Moscow Variation



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

POSITION PROMPT

White exchanges on f6, giving Black the bishop pair but avoiding the sharpest Anti-Moscow and Botvinnik complications.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. Bg5 h6 6. Bxf6 Qxf6 7. e3 Nd7 8. Bd3 dxc4 9. Bxc4 g6 10. O-O Bg7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

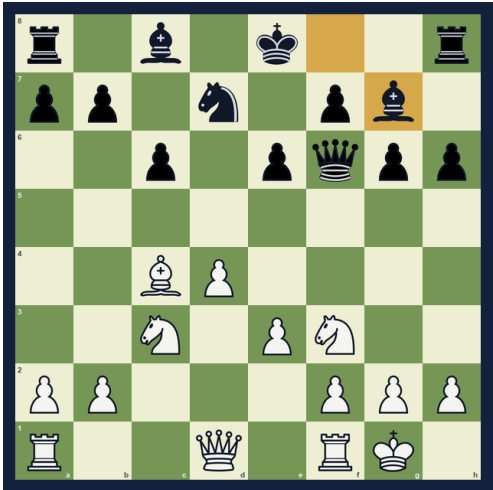
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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
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09. Moscow Variation



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

POSITION PROMPT

White exchanges on f6, giving Black the bishop pair but avoiding the sharpest Anti-Moscow and Botvinnik complications.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. Bg5 h6 6. Bxf6 Qxf6 7. e3 Nd7 8. Bd3 dxc4 9. Bxc4 g6 10. O-O Bg7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

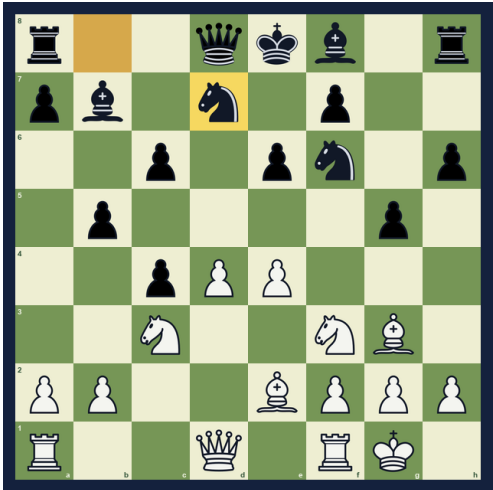
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THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

10. Anti-Moscow Gambit



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

POSITION PROMPT

White preserves the bishop with Bh4 and builds e4, entering a sharp gambit where development and central force matter more than immediate pawn recovery.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. Bg5 h6 6. Bh4 dxc4 7. e4 g5 8. Bg3 b5 9. Be2 Bb7 10. O-O Nbd7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

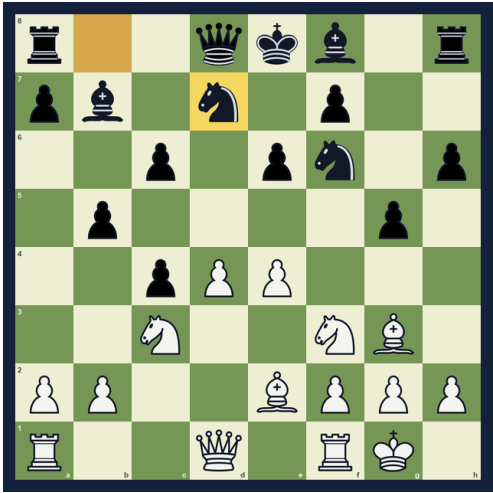
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THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

11. Anti-Moscow Gambit



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

POSITION PROMPT

White preserves the bishop with Bh4 and builds e4, entering a sharp gambit where development and central force matter more than immediate pawn recovery.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. Bg5 h6 6. Bh4 dxc4 7. e4 g5 8. Bg3 b5 9. Be2 Bb7 10. O-O Nbd7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

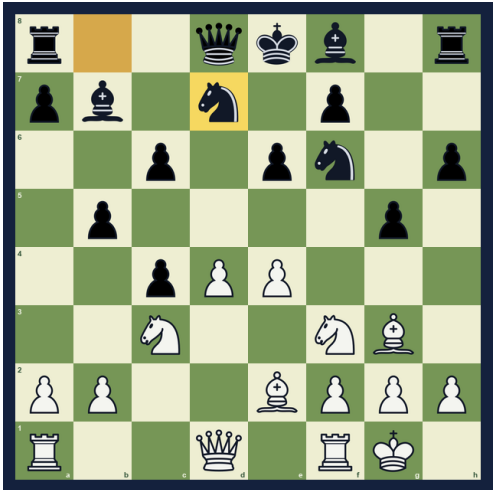
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- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
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FORECAST	__ / 2

12. Anti-Moscow Gambit



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

POSITION PROMPT

White preserves the bishop with Bh4 and builds e4, entering a sharp gambit where development and central force matter more than immediate pawn recovery.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. Bg5 h6 6. Bh4 dxc4 7. e4 g5 8. Bg3 b5 9. Be2 Bb7 10. O-O Nbd7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

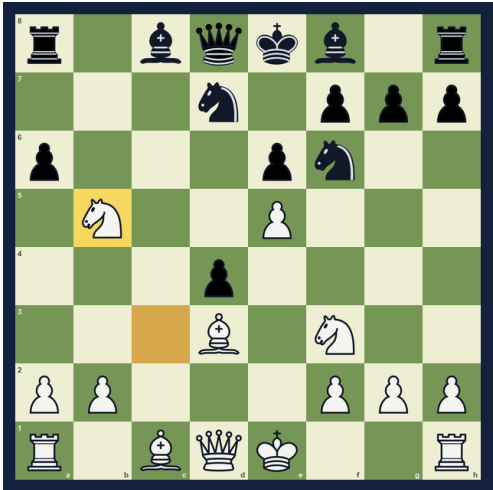
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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

13. Meran Main Line - Move-Order Lab



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

POSITION PROMPT

The Meran releases Black's light bishop with b5 and Bb7, while White builds e4-e5 and accepts a forcing central battle.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Bd3 dxc4 7. Bxc4 b5 8. Bd3 a6 9. e4 c5 10. e5 cxd4 11. Nxb5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

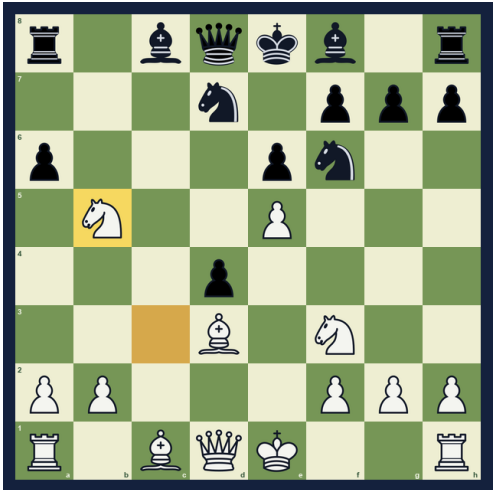
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THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

14. Meran Main Line - Plan Lab



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

POSITION PROMPT

Use the development lead to gain central space.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Bd3 dxc4 7. Bxc4 b5 8. Bd3 a6 9. e4 c5 10. e5 cxd4 11. Nxb5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

15. Meran Main Line - Break Lab



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

POSITION PROMPT

The Meran releases Black's light bishop with b5 and Bb7, while White builds e4-e5 and accepts a forcing central battle.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Bd3 dxc4 7. Bxc4 b5 8. Bd3 a6 9. e4 c5 10. e5 cxd4 11. Nxb5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

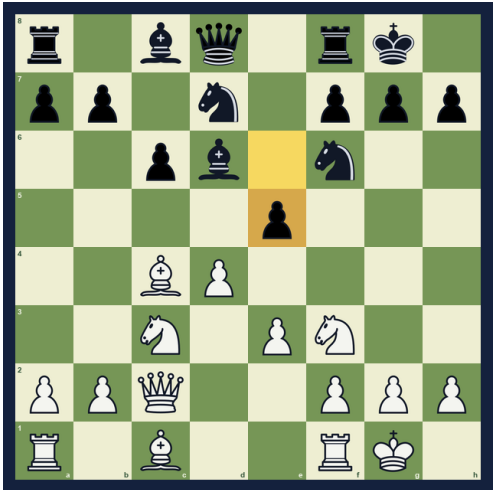
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THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

16. Anti-Meran with Qc2 - Trade Lab



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

POSITION PROMPT

Trade central pawns when the resulting open files favor White's developed pieces; avoid exchanges that solve Black's space problem.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Qc2 Bd6 7. Bd3 O-O 8. O-O dxc4 9. Bxc4 e5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

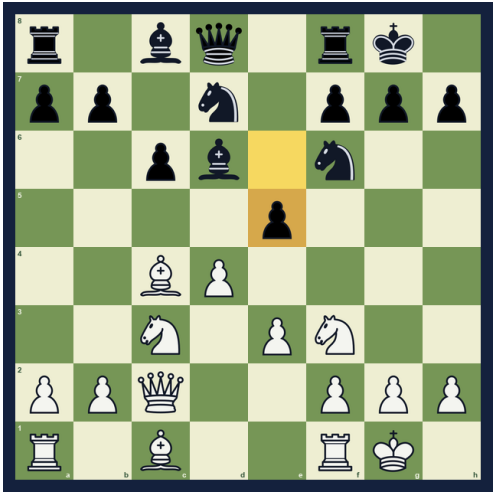
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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

17. Anti-Meran with Qc2 - Move-Order Lab



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

POSITION PROMPT

Qc2 supports e4, protects h7 pressure, and delays the bishop commitment so White can meet Meran ideas with more flexibility.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Qc2 Bd6 7. Bd3 O-O 8. O-O dxc4 9. Bxc4 e5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

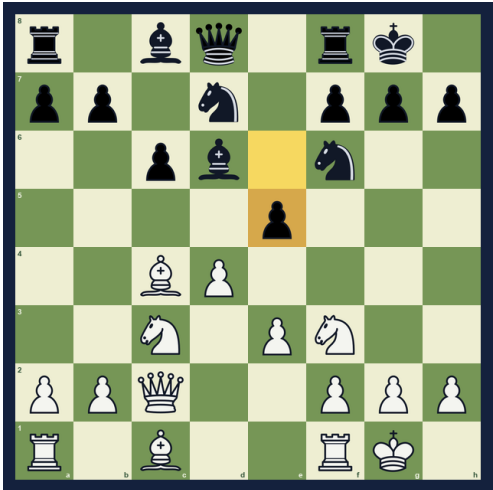
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THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

18. Anti-Meran with Qc2 - Plan Lab



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

POSITION PROMPT

Use Qc2, Bd3, and O-O to support central expansion.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Qc2 Bd6 7. Bd3 O-O 8. O-O dxc4 9. Bxc4 e5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

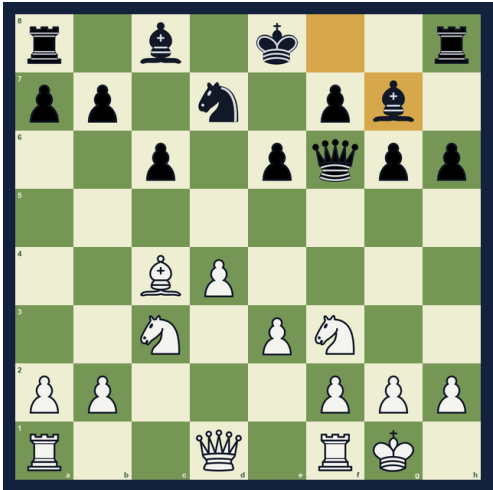
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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
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FORECAST	__ / 2

19. Moscow Variation - Break Lab



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

POSITION PROMPT

White exchanges on f6, giving Black the bishop pair but avoiding the sharpest Anti-Moscow and Botvinnik complications.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. Bg5 h6 6. Bxf6 Qxf6 7. e3 Nd7 8. Bd3 dxc4 9. Bxc4 g6 10. O-O Bg7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

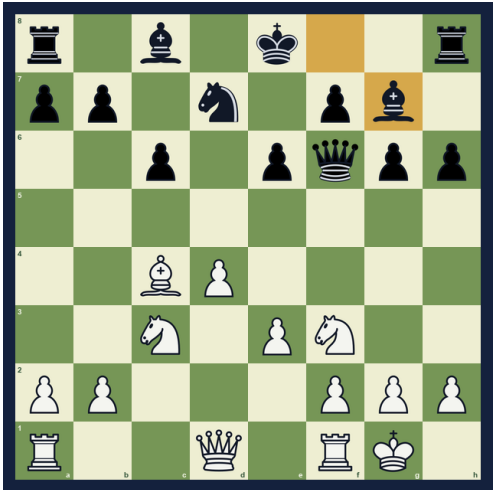
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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

20. Moscow Variation - Trade Lab



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

POSITION PROMPT

Trading the g5-bishop for the f6-knight is justified by reduced counterplay and tempo, not by a universal bishop-for-knight rule.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. Bg5 h6 6. Bxf6 Qxf6 7. e3 Nd7 8. Bd3 dxc4 9. Bxc4 g6 10. O-O Bg7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

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Monthly Retention Audit

Select ten random chapters and complete them under a ten-minute total limit. Track the categories you repeatedly miss: threat, candidate, structure, piece job, or forecast.

Do not restart the entire course. Return to the smallest group of chapters that repairs the repeated error, then test again in one week.